

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Pentecost 10

Another Kind of Freedom ~ Kin-dom Economics

9 August 2026



"Emerald Waves at Dusk"

*Chengming Liu / The 2nd International Aerial Photographer of the Year
Captured above the rolling hills of San Jose, California, at golden hour*

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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, Guest Organist

Passacaglia in C Minor, BWV 582, Johann Sebastian Bach (1685-1750)

Pastorale on "Bunessan", Jaebon Hwang (b. 1982)

Trio on "Ash Grove", Jaebon Hwang

Prelude and Fugue in D Major, BWV 532, Johann Sebastian Bach

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Cynthia Siadat & Rev. Fregin

Generously. Lavishly. Abundantly.
God spreads seeds of holy possibility far and wide.
Who will nurture their potential?
Who will tend their growth?

The Spirit of Life cries out for co-operation
so that love may blossom,
that justice may be a beautiful crop,
and that courage may grow unencumbered.

On this day, let not the gifts of God be wasted
but the harvest be plenty.
Let Divine Life flourish among us
and may all who long for God
join the labors of liberation.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

From Wisdom Emerging

FOUNDATION

From Wisdom emerging, we fashion a space
For people converging in safety and grace,
To shelter the freedom of one and of all
In Love without border or boundary or wall.

Faith's journey reclaiming, we blaze a new trail
With others, exclaiming: "Let justice prevail!"
Rejecting worn paths that oppress and mislead,
We walk in community, cherished and freed!

Forever exploring, we seek to learn more
Of Wisdom's outpouring, of Love's open door.
Amazed at the mysteries and graces we find,
We joyfully share them with all humankind.

The future progressing, we move through its change,
Old systems redressing, new patterns arrange;
Protecting the freedoms with every new choice,
We follow the Spirit and raise our clear voice!

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Loving God,
in the midst of the light and newness
of this day we confess,
many of our faces are lined with worry,
and our days are full of stress and struggle.

Yet we come to this time today,
grateful that in the midst of the uncertainty of our lives,
we have gathered to be reminded
of the hope that resides within your love.

*Surprise us now with your presence,
renew our sense of wonder;
keep us open to the gift of the Spirit of Life
present in our singing, our praying,
our speaking, and our living.
May it ever be so.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

Let All Things Now Living
Dr. Fahad Siadat, Conductor, Dr. Jaebon Hwang, Organ

TRADITIONAL WELSH
arr. KATHERINE DAVIS

***The Lord's Prayer**

Cynthia Siadat

*Weaver of Life, Ancient and Unfolding,
How sacred is your Presence!
We lean on your guidance.
We seek your love.
We open to your transformation.
Provide us bread in body and spirit
to sustain us in faith and solidarity.
Companion us with grace
as we seek to live lives of forgiveness and compassion,
repair and accountability.
We remember those who have supported us
as we seek to support others
in all the mess and glory of this human journey.
Guard our minds and hearts from the temptation of domination
and turn our loyalty away from the systems of evil.
For the whole cosmos hums with your wisdom.*

*Everything that lives, returns to your care.
Our thanks and honor to you,
Gracious Web of Existence,
Our Source and our Home.
Amen and Amen.*

[enfleshed]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

Though the mystery of God remains beyond our grasp,
the Spirit infuses us with glimpses of justice,
with touches of love,
and with whispers of truth.

Always and everywhere,
the Wisdom of God is being revealed
that we might live and love differently together -
free from the ways that destroy.

*Holy Mystery surround us now,
and reveal the ways of collective liberation.*

This morning may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from the Book of Acts*

Cynthia Siadat

All who believed were together and had all things in common; they would sell their possessions and goods and distribute the proceeds to all, as any had need. Day by day, as they spent much time together in the temple, they broke bread at home and ate their food with glad and generous hearts, praising God and having the goodwill of all the people.

For the witness and challenge of our ancestors...
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One, you are always and forever with us. You have offered us, and our ancestors before us, your life-giving presence - but we don't always respond to your invitations. The abundance of your world overwhelms us; your faithfulness surrounds us, and yet...we draw back.

You have shown us through Jesus, the humanity you hope can be ours. It all sounds so good God – freedom, justice, peace – but these things ask so much of us! And because we forget to rely on the help you offer through the Spirit of Life, we grow discouraged or indifferent...too easily. And yet, O God, we do want what you want – a new creation where we shall live, one and all, as one people.

On this day, Holy One, let this kind of newness begin with us – help us to forget what lies behind and turn our hearts and hands to what is ahead. Help us get free from the chains of guilt and self-pity, which stop our energy to love and our ability to *be* loved. Freshen up our hopes and dreams and help us make a new commitment to what lies before us.

And then, O God, bring us to a place, where we can help each other as we share in the mystery of life - and as we share the goodness of you.

*This we pray, creating with you, transforming God!
Amen and Amen.*

Meditation Anthem

Concord
Laude

BENJAMIN BRITTEN
TEXT: WILLIAM PLOMER

*Concord is here our days to bless. And this our land to endue with plenty, peace and happiness.
Concord. Concord and Time. Each needeth each. The ripest fruit hangs where not one,
but only two. Only two can reach.*

Sermon

Kin-dom Economics

Rev. Michael Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

We give thanks for the invitation to be at this table,
for here we are shown our lives...

The daily bread of work and care,
the cup of delight, pressed from the fruits of creativity
and our brokenness, with all its pain and self-knowledge.

We celebrate the life that is ours
for we know we are precious in your sight.
We celebrate the life that is yours,
which has become a pattern of reality for us:
It is as this love is revealed,
given and received
that we are able to put love into action.

We give thanks for the Spirit of New Life
active in our lives
as it was in the life of Jesus.

At this gathering in this sacred place
we take bread as Jesus took bread,
and we remember as Jesus remembered,
the constant presence
of the Spirit of Life and Love.

We break and share this bread
as Jesus broke and shared it.

We share this bread as our pledge of openness
to the Spirit in our midst,
and in acknowledgement
of our eternal connectedness with the Spirit of Life.

We take this fruit of the vine and pour it as Jesus poured it.

We drink as Jesus invited their friends to drink,
mindful of the relationship of love and trust
between ourselves and the Spirit of Life,
believing as Jesus believed,
that beyond pain and shadows and death,
life in the Spirit continues
in ways beyond our imagining.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Cynthia Siadat

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

Like a River Glorious JOHN MOUNTAIN arr. CHRISTINE ANDERSON
Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Bells*, Donald Brown, *Piano* & JOHN CARTER

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Cynthia Siadat

Holy One, through the offering of these gifts
may we become a more open people.
Help us to be more open-minded in listening for your Word and wisdom,
open-hearted in working to heal a broken world,
open-handed in giving to those in need.

*With thanks for all good gifts, we present a portion
of our substance - and the whole of ourselves.*

*We offer this prayer with hope for the freedom of all.
Amen and Amen!*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

For freedom,
the Holy One has set us free!
No longer bound by fear;
Not tempted towards
destruction!
Love is our salvation and
justice is our cause.
With the Spirit as our guide,
We shall not be moved.
-enfleshed

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

Dona Nobis Pacem, *from B Minor Mass*
Brandon Harris, *Conductor*, Dr. Jaebon Hwang, *Organ*
Grant Us Peace

J.S.BACH

***Hymn for the Journey**

Come, See the Fullness

BUNESSAN

God the Creator gave in abundance all of the wonder we now behold;
Colors of glory, everyday beauty, echo the story of God's deep love.

Bold as the sunlight, tender as nightfall, love shaped the heav'n's height; love filled the seas.
Love formed the flowers, called for the living; marked out the hours of time to be.

Come, see the fullness – Life we've been given; beauty and promise, myst'r'y and hope.
Laughter and weeping, vision and purpose; friends for the keeping, strength for the road.

Open your hearts wide, teach us your wisdom lest our days pass by empty and small.
May we be witness with your creation – to your great kindness given to all.

Postlude

Dr. Jaebon Hwang, Guest Organist

Fugue in G Major, "Gigue", BWV 577, Johann Sebastian Bach

Inside The Music

"Today marks the beginning of a transition in the life of our church as Dr. Fahad Siadat and I begin our roles as Co-Interim Directors of Music & Arts at the Cathedral. Within the framework of the church, I am still in my current interim role with First Kids First as Claire Kelly continues her maternity leave, as I help to organize and plan music from afar, joining the chancel again in September. On the chancel today is the beautiful reflection of collaborative efforts of community as we march on with Grace and Don on the bells and piano, both Fahad and Brandon at the choir's helm, our guest organist Dr. Hwang while Christoph continues his much deserved time at home, and the ever-present solid foundation of our choir of professionals and faithfully committed volunteers in singing leadership. I felt that this tangible and active definition of the term *co-operation* was especially apropos to the theme of the day: *Kin-dom Economics*.

It is for this reason that I have centralized one of my favorite poems as the Meditation Anthem: William Plomer's *Concord* which simply states, "*Concord and Time, each needeth each. The ripest fruit hangs where not one, but only two can reach.*" And isn't this the economic structure to which we are called and that which we know most healthfully benefits all? That when *ALL things now living can celebrate in joy and thanksgiving*, as we sing in our introit, we can together enjoy *the river glorious* (as Grace illustrates through bells), and achieve the peace about which we triumphantly and proactively sing in Bach's setting of that urgent imperative—*grant us peace* (in choral response). And in the pursuit of all these things we know: *each needeth each: the ripest fruit hangs where not one, but only two can reach.*" ~ Dr. Ianthi Marini